juncture if that was the intention. Incidentally, Bhajan Lal was the leading exponent, if not the father, of the '*Aya Ram Gaya Ram* ' practice in Indian politics (party hopping based on political opportunism; literally, someone who comes and goes) before he joined the Congress party.

The Asian Games were to begin on 19 November in Delhi. Haryana police, who controlled the main access points from Punjab to Delhi, were ordered not to let any Sikh enter the capital without proper verification. Consequently, not even persons like former Air Chief Marshal (later Marshal of the Air Force) Arjan Singh and Lt Gen. Jagjit Singh Arora (Retd), who accepted the instrument of surrender of the Pakistan Army at Dhaka at the end of Bangladesh Liberation War (both residents of Delhi returning from Punjab), were spared by the Haryana police. They were allowed to proceed only after being subjected to search and questioning. A total of 1,500 Sikhs were detained as potential demonstrators. Though the Games passed off peacefully and Rajiv Gandhi got accolades for a job well done, it left a bitter taste in the mouth for Sikhs in Delhi and Punjab.

The failure of the November 1982 talks and the ruthless manner in which Haryana police treated the Sikhs in Haryana and those transiting through Haryana to reach Delhi led Harchand Singh Longowal to call a convention of ex-servicemen at the Golden Temple in December 1982. Over 5,000 former officers and soldiers turned up at this meeting.

Alarmed at the turnout and the mood of the participants at that meeting, the Central government resumed negotiations with Akali Dal leaders on 24 January 1983. To these talks, opposition leaders were also invited. Senior Communist Party of India (Marxist) leader and MP from Punjab Harkishan Singh Surjeet was one of them. He told Mark Tully that significant progress was made and that these talks would have succeeded had the government allowed the use of the same amount of river waters by Punjab as it was drawing at that time, pending the final decision of a tribunal on that issue. [26]

Though the talks with the Akalis had failed by February, Indira Gandhi subsequently visited Gurudwara Bangla Sahib in New Delhi and abruptly announced that the government had accepted all the